after his appointment, a leading newspaper would write ‘that Mr Ratan Tata was the heir apparent was indicated several years earlier’. Even JRD’s official biographer, R.M. Lala, made a similar comment, but he too did so some four years after Ratan had become the chairman. Lala then wrote that JRD had, in 1988, ‘carefully laid the groundwork for Ratan Tata to take over three years later in 1991’. The conclusion of the official biographer may, however, have been reached with the benefit of hindsight.

Ratan’s father Naval Tata shared the same opinion as Lala. Speaking to a magazine in 1988, he said: ‘[JRD] has already, through a spontaneous gesture, prepared Ratan Tata to take over his mantle.’ But in actuality, nothing was promised to Ratan and nothing was preordained. JRD did not decide on him almost until the last minute. The final decision was made only after the group chairman had carefully weighed his attributes and suitability over several years. Throughout the 1980s, Ratan was watched over by JRD for qualities that would qualify him for a larger assignment. His elevation, therefore, did not come easy; neither was he groomed for the job. He had to prove himself at each stage.

Narrowing the Choice

For the most part of the 1980s, the choice of JRD’s successor was wide open. His style of functioning had thrown up many contenders. JRD worked through ‘empowering people’. He was also a master delegator and had built a team of celebrated industrial leaders. As he said: ‘I didn’t bring together a bunch of yes men. I wanted a team of competent, aggressive people who know their own minds.’ Over the years, these leaders gained fame as heads of some of the notable Tata companies.

Compared to them, Ratan seemed, to a casual observer, somewhat less glamorous. His understated mannerism of not speaking about his achievements, his extreme reluctance to promote himself and his reticence were mistaken to indicate a lack of confidence and reflect his incompetence, making him unsuitable for the corner officer in Bombay House. For many, he could not be a leader as he had a perceived problem in communicating with large groups of people. He was more comfortable with a smaller group, commented a leading magazine.

Not everyone agreed with this view, though. B. Muthuraman, former MD and vice chairman of Tata Steel, says: ‘Give him a stage and Ratan is